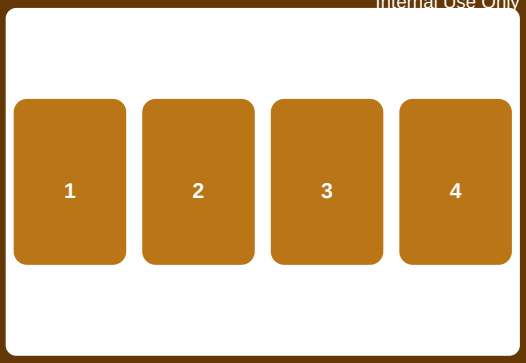
OPERATIONS

Bottleneck Walk

Physically walk a process to identify the specific constraining step that limits overall system throughput.



WHEN TO USE

When total output is below target but individual steps appear busy; when lead time is unexpectedly or consistently long.

HOW TO APPLY — STEPS

1. Walk the process physically from start to finish
2. Observe and measure queue lengths at each step — the longest queue is upstream of the bottleneck
3. Measure actual cycle times at each process step
4. Confirm the step with the lowest effective capacity is the bottleneck
5. Focus ALL available improvement resources on that single constraint

PRACTITIONER TIP

! The bottleneck is almost never where management thinks it is. Always walk before drawing any conclusions.

KEY OUTPUTS

- Bottleneck identification with evidence
- Cycle time comparison chart across all steps
- Capacity model showing the constraint

HOW TO MEASURE SUCCESS

System throughput increase after bottleneck action; queue length reduction at the constraint

TOOL CATEGORY
Operations